

TEAM INDIA: THEIR TOUGHEST SEASON YET

ODIS VS ENGLAND

Aug 21: 1st ODI, Southampton (d/n)
 Aug 24: 2nd ODI, Bristol (d/n)
 Aug 27: 3rd ODI Birmingham
 Aug 30: 4th ODI Manchester (d/n)
 Sept 2: 5th ODI, Leeds
 Sept 5: 6th ODI, Oval
 Sept 8: 7th ODI, Lords

TWENTY20 WORLD CUP

Sept 13: India v Scotland, Durban (d/n)
 Sept 14: India v Pakistan, Durban (d/n)

ODI SERIES VS AUSTRALIA

Sept 29: 1st ODI, Bangalore (d/n)
 Oct: 2nd ODI, Kochi
 Oct 5: 3rd ODI, Hyderabad
 Oct 8: 4th ODI, Chandigarh
 Oct 11: 5th ODI, Vadodara
 Oct 14: 6th ODI, Nagpur
 Oct 17: 7th ODI, Mumbai (d/n)
 Oct 20: Twenty20 v Australia

SERIES VS PAKISTAN

Nov 6: 1st ODI, Guwahati
 Nov 9: 2nd ODI, Chandigarh (d/n)
 Nov 12: 3rd ODI, Kanpur
 Nov 15: 4th ODI, Gwalior
 Nov 18: 5th ODI, Jaipur
 Nov 22-26: 1st Test, Delhi
 Nov 30-Dec 4: 2nd Test, Kolkata
 Dec 8-12: 3rd Test, Bangalore

TOUR OF AUSTRALIA

Dec 26-30: 1st Test, Melbourne
 Jan 2-6: 2nd Test, Sydney
 Jan 16-20: 3rd Test, Perth
 Jan 24-28: 4th Test, Adelaide
 Feb 1: Twenty20 Melbourne (d/n)

ODI SERIES V AUSTRALIA & SRI LANKA

Feb 3: v Australia, Brisbane (d/n)
 Feb 5: v Sri Lanka, Brisbane (d/n)
 Feb 10: v Australia, Melbourne (d/n)
 Feb 12: v Sri Lanka, Canberra
 Feb 17: v Australia, Adelaide (d/n)
 Feb 19: v Sri Lanka, Adelaide (d/n)
 Feb 24: v Australia, Sydney (d/n)
 Feb 26: v Sri Lanka, Hobart



AP PHOTO TOM HEVEZI



TOP SCORER: Dinesh Karthik raises his bat after his 50 during the second day of the second Test at Trent Bridge

a tangible difference being wary of Steve Waugh's Australia, the only team insane enough to think it can chase 443 to win, and Vaughan's fading England, Ganguly and Dravid had had to make exactly the same choice. Their teams had worked too hard and too long to squander a square inch of advantage gained. The import of that decision was lost on no one. Ganguly and Dravid, two men, two Indian captains, different in every way it is possible to be, did exactly the same thing.

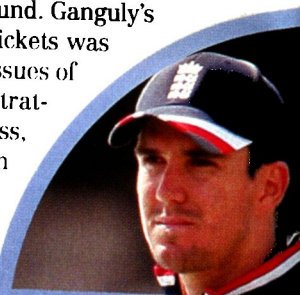
After a year in the job, it is this series rather than any that has gone before it, which has been the making of Dravid the captain. Had he lost, it is unlikely he would have had the stomach to continue. He has worked at finding a more relaxed, less micro-management style of functioning, content to delegate duties and let those given the duties carry them out as they will. On the eve of the final day at the Oval, he slept fitfully, as is his habit during Test matches, but en route to the ground the next morning said he, "felt a calm".

Far removed from gung-ho catchphrases like 'now or never', the word 'calm' seems to be the informal Zen-like mantra for the tour. Insiders talk of a dressing room where the air is clear, as if its attendant tension and anxiety have ebbed away with the departure of ex-coach Greg Chappell.

The aristocratic Australian may have been an intellectually stimulating ideas man but contributed little to collective harmony. He could have done, say members of the touring party, with less "malice" and "fractiousness" about everything and more of a "willingness to open up to people". Since his departure, India has lost just one match, an ODI against South Africa, with much the same team.

Virtually without specific delegation or instruction, tasks and expertise were shared around. Ganguly's ability to read wickets was sought after on issues of overall match strategy and the toss, younger batsmen gravitated towards

Tendulkar and the senior pros, and Khan took on the job of choosing the ball with which India would open the bowling. Said one member of team India, "It's about winning... People become far more tolerant of each



"Should wrap up this soon, boys, HARRY POTTER'S come out to bat."

KEVIN PIETERSEN welcomes S. SREESANTH to the wicket.